

Recognize it

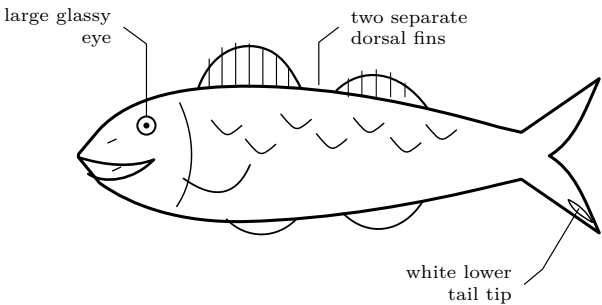
Olive-gold fish with cloudy reflective eye, canine teeth, and white tip on lower tail lobe.

Body	Elongate; separate spiny and soft dorsal fins; dark saddle markings.
Mouth/fins	Large toothed mouth; sharp rear edge on gill cover.
Confusion	Sauger has spots on dorsal fin and no strong white lower-tail tip.

Lake role

Where it belongs
Hard/soft transitions, points, weed edges, basin prey, and low-light shallows.
Food and season
Fish predator; moves with light, temperature, current, and forage.

Identification plate



Find it on these waters

Pine	Search deep hard breaks and outside weedline by day; test shallower windward edges in low light.
North	Test narrows/current, weed-to-hard-bottom edges, and evening flats beside depth.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Presentations

- 1. **Jig and minnow/plastic.** Use the lightest head that keeps bottom contact without plowing.
- 2. **Slip rig or float.** Slow live bait along a marked contour or suspend it just above fish.
- 3. **Stop rule.** No bottom transition, prey, or marks after a controlled pass means move; do not troll memories.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Wet hands, avoid gill cover and dorsal spines, use pliers, and support the fish level.

Water-specific rule	May 2, 2026–Mar 7, 2027; 18-in minimum; daily bag 3 on both lakes.
Kitchen choice	Choose a legal lower-end fish rather than a large adult; check length-based consumption advice.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin’s Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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